less buoyant than usual among the electorate. Will they hang a tad heavy on the core saffron voter? As an extension, will these chieftains be able to retain their near-monopoly over their specific caste cohorts—the Rajbhars, Nishads and Kurmis, respectively? These three are big segments of the non-Yadav OBC spectrum in UP and their support had been crucial in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) bagging 11 out of these 13 seats in 2019—the BJP winning nine, the AD(S) two. The remaining two, Ghosi and Ghazipur, had gone to the BSP.

The three caste party leaders have high stakes in the game. AD(S) chief Anupriya Patel is seeking a third term from Mirzapur, the SBSP chief's son Arvind Rajbhar is in the fray from Ghosi, and the NISHAD Party chief's son Praveen Nishad, outgoing Sant Kabir Nagar MP, is in the race again. To cover all bets, the BJP has also brought ex-UP minister and turncoat Dara Singh Chauhan back into the fold (he has a following among the Nonia Chauhans, another key OBC community). But ground reports suggest the clout these parties wield with their communities could be tested this time. The Opposition—the Samajwadi Party (SP) especially—has gone with caste combinations that show a clear intent to make an ingress into their turf. Recent electoral history also casts their monopoly in doubt: Dara had lost the Ghosi assembly seat bypoll in late 2023 by some 42,000 votes despite full NDA backing. Now to expect him to provide cover fire for a tenuous main flank could be a less than foolproof arrangement.

Read that in the context of the Opposition SP-Congress alliance trying out a newly-spun 'PDA' formula—an attempt to create an umbrella vote of the 'Pichhda (backwards), Dalit and Alpasankhyak (minorities)'—to regain lost ground in the region. There had historically been no great Public Display of Affection between the SP's Yadav core and the other OBC blocs, and that's what had set off this fragmentation of these Mandal segments. This time, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has opted for non-Yadav candidates everywhere save for his handful of family seats. In Purvanchal, their *ummeedvars* (candidates) tick boxes like Nishad, Bind and Kurmi. That is no automatic guarantee of loyalty, of course, so Akhilesh's electoral rhetoric floats above this, tapping into themes common to all: his speeches have kept the focus on question paper leaks, farm loan waivers and a legal MSP. A common line is that the BJP government wrote off Rs 25 lakh crore in loans of its favourite industrialists in the past 10 years but did not waive farm loans.

On paper, the SP-Congress has reasons to consider Ghazipur, Ghosi and Mirzapur as surefire seats. In the 2022 assembly election, the SP-led alliance had

BRAJ TO AWADH,

In the absence of a wave, caste dynamics and loc

PASHCHIM UP
Vital factors: RLD, Muslim unity

SEATS: 14



West UP is a cauldron dominated by Dalits, Muslims, Jats, Gujjars and Rajputs. With Jayant Chaudhary's RLD moving to the NDA at the last moment, the BJP-led alliance seems stronger though the INDIA

BRAJ-ROHILKHAND
Vital factor: Bipolar contest

SEATS: 14

The lower Doab Braj-speaking region, situated on the banks of the river Yamuna, seems to be facing a bipolar contest between the NDA and INDIA blocs. Mainpuri and Kannauj could be considered VIP seats here, with SP chief Akhilesh Yadav and wife Dimple both contesting the polls. Their daughter Aditi campaigning for them this time, they have gained a lot of traction on social media.

In northwest UP's Rohilkhand, Muslim voters will play an important role, especially in Rampur (50 per cent of the population), Sambhal (52 per cent), Moradabad (47 per cent), Bareilly (30 per cent), Pilibhit (25 per cent) and Budaun (20 per cent). But despite this, the BJP had swept Rohilkhand in the 2014 and 2019 LS polls (except for Budaun in 2014). Key contests: In family bastion Mainpuri, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav's wife Dimple Yadav faced off with the BJP's Jaiveer Singh, the tourism minister in the Yogi Adityanath government. The BSP had given the ticket to former BJP legislator Shiv Prasad Yadav to cut the Yadav votes in this seat.

Senior SP leader Shivpal Yadav's son Aditya Yadav made his debut in Budaun.

ANI

